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Louis H. OK

~~TOP SECRET~~

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MEMORANDUM FOR THE PRESIDENT:

The following notes contain a summary of the discussion at the 74th Meeting of the National Security Council, at which you presided.

1. U. S. POSITION REGARDING A CEASE-FIRE IN KOREA

SECRETARY ACHESON said that there was urgent need for a decision on this subject. He said that we were agreed with the British that neither of us should propose a cease-fire. The British, however, would support one if no conditions were attached. He said that the 13 Asian countries were about to propose a resolution which would be very bad and gets worse as it goes along. He thought the ideal solution would be to have the President of the General Assembly pick out two people to confer with the UN Commander and the Chinese. He wished, however, to get the military viewpoint on this question.

MR. RUSK said that he had been discussing this question with senior officers in Defense. There are numerous military problems involved. For one thing, a cease-fire might enable the enemy to build up his forces without air attack by us. For another, it might conflict with our plans for the 10th Corps. It might also involve the 38th parallel, whereas our present position is militarily stronger. Finally, if we had a cease-fire there would be only three ways of having an eventual disengagement: The first would be complete victory, which now appears impossible. The second would be our being driven out of Korea, which we will try to prevent. The third is establishment of some form of equilibrium in Korea.

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Mr. Rusk said that it appears we must establish some line where we can consolidate our forces. The problem is how to have a cease-fire without falling into one of the traps. He suggested we might want to tell the Asian countries that, rather than putting in their resolution, they should propose that the President of the General Assembly arrange for the negotiations. There is, however, no assurance that the Asians will accept anything other than their proposed resolution. State, however, must know whether we want a cease-fire in the vicinity of the 38th parallel.

THE PRESIDENT said that he thought having the President of the General Assembly arrange for the negotiations of a cease-fire was the best solution.

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MR. RUSK suggested that we must know the terms before we accept a cease-fire.

THE PRESIDENT said that he had made it clear to Prime Minister Attlee that we would not surrender to these murderous Chinese Communists. We will have to be pushed out, and that will take them a long time.

GENERAL BRADLEY said that one condition would have to be free inspection of both sides by a UN commission, since otherwise they would be able to build up their forces and supplies.

THE PRESIDENT agreed that there should be free access to all of Korea, since we can't sit still and let the enemy build up.

SECRETARY MARSHALL noted that a cease-fire would stop all air reconnaissance and might push our Navy back. They could then have a large build-up and if we objected they would say that we had not lived up to the cease-fire. On the other hand, if we oppose a cease-fire our friends would think that we were objecting to a peaceful solution. He thought that we must find some position that appears reasonable, even if the other side refuses to accept it. He thought there should be free access to both sides by a UN commission which was big enough to see what was happening. The commission should check large movements, particularly a build-up of supplies. The commission would probably have to be composed of nations that were not on either side. Secretary Marshall was fearful of the Indians being on the commission.

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SECRETARY ACHESON suggested there might be three-man teams composed of one representative each of General MacArthur, the Chinese Communists, and the UN.

MR. RUSK said that the UN Korean Commission could go into operation quickly by getting neutral members.

SECRETARY ACHESON asked whether it was possible, before a cease-fire is negotiated, for the Communists to build up and throw us farther back.

GENERAL BRADLEY guessed not, since he doesn't believe they have enough supplies.

SECRETARY ACHESON asked if we were building up our supplies.

GENERAL BRADLEY said ours are in pretty good shape except for food, which would have to be brought in even under a cease-fire.

SECRETARY ACHESON said that General Collins indicated that we planned to hold a line farther south. He suggested we might be better where we are since, if there is no cease-fire, we may be pushed back south of Seoul.

GENERAL BRADLEY said the strongest military position is in the south, about half-way between Pusan and the 38th parallel. Another good position is just south of the 38th parallel.

In answer to Secretary Marshall, General Bradley said that the 38th parallel would be a good demarcation line for a cease-fire.

ADMIRAL DAVIS said that the Deputy Chiefs of Staff had been meeting, and had agreed that from a military point of view it was preferable not to have a cease-fire. If we had one, however, it should be preceded by terms. Otherwise there would be a chaotic condition where the cease-fire was honored more in the breach. The terms would have to cover reinforcements, movement, suitable line, and other points. Among the other points would be that the line should not be the 38th parallel, which is not a natural defense line. Also, the Chinese should not be able to strengthen their forces. We should also be able to move the 10th Corps wherever we please. If there was a cease-fire, naval and air action would be stopped.

SECRETARY MARSHALL agreed that we must arrive at acceptable terms. We must insist on effective committee supervision of both sides.

THE PRESIDENT agreed that terms should be arrived at before a cease-fire.

SECRETARY MARSHALL pointed out the difference in the concept of reinforcements. He said that General MacArthur would have to be able to get replacements, whereas the Chinese might use that excuse for a further build-up.

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GENERAL BRADLEY suggested that if the UN commission could inspect ports it might be the same as a blockade.

SECRETARY ACHESON read a proposed statement of policy, which was amended and agreed.

THE VICE PRESIDENT felt that it was important that we not get in a position of opposing a cease-fire. He felt that the terms should be worked out in advance and that the UN commission idea sounded sensible.

GENERAL BRADLEY asked for guidance as to whether we wanted to order UN forces back to the 38th parallel.

THE PRESIDENT said that we have got to hold our present positions as tenaciously as possible while we get our troops in the northeast back before a cease-fire.

SECRETARY MARSHALLpointed out that present plans call for a careful retirement, and he presumed the President does not want to hold that up.

THE PRESIDENT agreed, but said that he did not want us forced to make a hurried withdrawal. He does not want to make a political decision to pull back, and he feels the present directive covers the situation.

SECRETARY ACHESON said that from a political viewpoint it would be desirable if there were no decision which represented the 38th parallel as having any validity.

THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL:

a. Agreed to recommend to the President the following statement of policy on the subject:

"We will consider a cease-fire, but must insist upon a cease-fire which does not place UN forces at a military disadvantage and which does not involve political concessions. Details of a cease-fire should be negotiated in order to protect the security of UN forces before a cease-fire is accepted. The Joint Chiefs of Staff will prepare as a matter of urgency the military conditions on which a cease-fire would be acceptable."

b. Noted the President's approval of the above statement of policy.

NOTE: The above statement of policy subsequently transmitted to the Secretary of State for implementation in any negotiations, and to the Secretary of Defense for implementation by the Joint Chiefs of Staff of the last sentence thereof.

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2. RESULTS OF THE RECENT TALKS WITH PRIME MINISTER ATTLEE

THE PRESIDENT stated the original purpose of the meeting as indicated in the agenda. He thought that the meetings with Prime Minister Attlee had been successful. There was only one basic disagreement regarding the attitude toward the Chinese Communists.

SECRETARY ACHESON read a brief summary of the agreements reached. He said that it had come out clearly how important close relationship with the United Kingdom is, since we can bring U. S. power into play only with the cooperation of the British.

THE PRESIDENT said that this was true both in the Atlantic and in the Pacific. He noted that it had also been agreed that it would be terrible to get tied down in a war with the Chinese Communists.

SECRETARY MARSHALL questioned whether it was not agreed that war with China should be avoided.

GENERAL BRADLEY noted that we had reserved the right to take action against the Chinese Communists, although we did not desire to be tied down there.

SECRETARY MARSHALL thought that we had indicated we did not want to be restrained from bombing Chinese bases, although we would not do it for other than the protection of our units. He also thought that we had agreed on the strategic importance of the offshore island chain.

THE PRESIDENT noted that the British had changed their position on Formosa.

THE VICE PRESIDENT asked if it wasn't agreed that we would not precipitate a general war with China.

THE PRESIDENT agreed, but said that we made it clear that we would not stand idly by.

SECRETARY MARSHALL suggested, and it was agreed, that the NSC Staff prepare recommendations resulting from the meetings.

THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL:

a. Discussed the results of the recent talks with Prime Minister Attlee.

b. In order that coordinated action may be taken as soon as possible by the Executive Branch of the Government to implement the agreements reached in the talks with Prime Minister Attlee, directed the NSC Staff to review these agreements and submit to the Council for consideration the courses of action which should now be taken, including not only direct implementing action but the revision of existing NSC reports or the preparation of new reports, in the light of the agreements reached and differences revealed at the talks.

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3. PROCLAMATION OF A NATIONAL EMERGENCY

THE PRESIDENT said that he wished to discuss the advisability of declaring a national emergency, which he was considering doing on Wednesday or Thursday.

SECRETARY MARSHALL said that our position in Korea now appears more secure. There is a reasonable chance of establishing a fairly strong line, since we can get our troops from the northeast

to join the others. Another problem is reinforcements for Formosa. The general situation, however, is just as dangerous as it ever was.

Secretary Marshall said that his reason for telling a Congressional committee that the President was considering the declaration of a national emergency was to temper down demands for full mobilization. He thought his statement seemed to have the desired effect. If the national emergency were declared, the necessary powers would then be made available to the President and the people would be made more aware of the critical situation. Until he made this statement, Secretary Marshall said, the Congressional committee seemed on the edge of very aggressive action.

Secretary Marshall said that the question of the Western European build-up has to be considered in connection with the declaration. However, we must have a declaration of emergency unless Congress revokes the restrictive action on the President.

THE PRESIDENT said that he felt that we must make a declaration of national emergency.

GENERAL SMITH read a memorandum estimating probable Soviet reactions to full-scale mobilization by the U. S. (filed with the Minutes of the meeting).

SECRETARY MARSHALL said that he thought we must consider the effect of a declaration on our NATO actions, particularly the designation of a Supreme Commander. He felt that the proposed NATO meeting must be carried out and that we should proceed to appoint a Supreme Commander. He also agreed that we must proceed on German rearmament, but felt that we must prepare a very careful program. He suggested a re-examination of our strategic analysis of Soviet reaction to rearming the Germans. He felt that strong statements on this would be a dangerous thing. The Russians might protest and even go to war to prevent it. The same thing applies to the Japanese Peace Treaty.

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Secretary Marshall expressed the opinion, however, that we can't avoid going ahead with German rearmament. The problem is how to manage it politically. We can't sit still. Our political actions must be tempered so as not to exaggerate the immediate effects, but we must not stop doing what we need to do. We must handle our propaganda as expertly as possible, since Russian propaganda may scare France and other countries. This is a difficult gamble to get into, but we must do it as cleverly as we can. We must proceed to build an integrated defense force in Europe as enthusiastically as possible. Secretary Marshall felt that General Eisenhower would be able to do a lot with the French, particularly if General Juin takes over command there, which would offer great hope. On the major solution of our program, however, we do not have much choice, even in the timing.

In answer to a question by the Vice President regarding the extent of authority of the German Government, SECRETARY ACHESON said that it has none in the military field. This would have to be worked out first before we could go ahead.

GENERAL SMITH referred to a recent Communist propaganda line coming out of Trieste. He said it represented a radical change in the party line, particularly in giving the idea that the Russians might attack first.

THE PRESIDENT asked Secretary Snyder whether we were in shape financially.

SECRETARY SNYDER said that we needed a declaration of national emergency to convince Congress. He said that one side of Congress is pushing very hard, while another side is lagging and not voting taxes, saying that we have plenty of time. Any steps taken now will have no fiscal impact before May or June, and by that time we can get organized to handle it.

THE PRESIDENT explained that he had been studying this question a long time with the NSC, that he was meeting with his economic staff later this afternoon regarding actions at home, and that he was having a meeting of Congressional leaders on Wednesday to outline a program of action and inform them of his decision regarding the declaration of a national emergency. Thursday or Friday night the President expects to make a national broadcast to explain the situation and needle people to take the necessary action.

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THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL:

a. Discussed the situation the U. S. now faces and certain steps which now appear to be necessary, including the possible declaration of a national emergency and probable Soviet reaction thereto.

b. Agreed to advise the President that the declaration of a national emergency appears necessary in order to enable the U. S. to take the steps required in the interests of national security.

NOTE: The action in b above subsequently submitted to the President for consideration.